GOVERNMENT OF INDIA

Ministry of Tribal Affairs

Empowering Tribal Communities, Preserving Heritage

Confidential and Proprietory
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SHRI NARENDRA MODI

HONORABLE PRIME MINISTER, INDIA



MESSAGE

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SHRI JUAL ORAM

HONORABLE MINISTER,
MINISTRY OF TRIBAL AFFAIRS



MESSAGE

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SHRI MUNINDRA KUMAR

DIRECTOR GENERAL, CHAMBER OF COMMERCE AND INDUSTRIES OF INDIA



MESSAGE

India's tribal communities represent a rich repository of cultural heritage, traditional knowledge, natural resource stewardship, and sustainable living practices. The Ministry of Tribal Affairs plays a vital role in promoting the socio-economic development of tribal communities through education, healthcare, livelihood generation, entrepreneurship, infrastructure development, and inclusive governance while preserving their unique cultural identity.

The Chamber of Commerce and Industries of India (CCI India) believes that empowering tribal communities is essential for achieving balanced and inclusive national development. Through policy advocacy, entrepreneurship promotion, market linkages, investment facilitation, skill development, technology adoption, capacity building, and sustainable livelihood initiatives, CCI India remains committed to supporting the Ministry's vision of creating opportunities that enhance economic participation while respecting cultural heritage.

This Knowledge Paper provides comprehensive insights into the Ministry's strategic priorities, policy framework, flagship programmes, institutional initiatives, and emerging opportunities across tribal entrepreneurship, education, healthcare, forest-based livelihoods, handicrafts, digital inclusion, ecotourism, skill development, and sustainable community development. It also identifies collaborative pathways that can strengthen tribal economies through innovation and responsible investment.

The publication serves as a strategic resource for policymakers, tribal institutions, entrepreneurs, investors, development organizations, researchers, academic institutions, industry leaders, financial organizations, and civil society stakeholders committed to advancing tribal development. Through collaborative engagement and knowledge sharing, it aims to promote inclusive growth, preserve traditional knowledge, strengthen livelihoods, and improve quality of life.

As India progresses towards inclusive and sustainable development, empowering tribal communities will remain integral to national progress. CCI India looks forward to partnering with the Ministry of Tribal Affairs in creating opportunities that foster dignity, prosperity, and inclusive growth for tribal communities across the country.

Munindra Kumar
Director General
CCI India

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Preface

The Ministry of Tribal Affairs occupies a position of profound constitutional and moral significance in India's governance architecture. Governing a population of approximately 10.45 crore Scheduled Tribe (ST) citizens who represent 8.6 percent of India's total population, the Ministry is the primary instrument through which the State fulfils its constitutional obligations toward some of the most geographically isolated, economically marginalised, and culturally distinct communities in the nation. These communities inhabit 26 percent of India's total land area, including some of the most biodiversity-rich forests and resource-endowed regions in South and Southeast Asia.

The national development context within which this Knowledge Paper is prepared is one of simultaneous opportunity and urgency. India's Viksit Bharat 2047 vision rests on the foundational principle that development must be inclusive - that the nation's prosperity cannot be measured in aggregate GDP without accounting for the welfare of its most vulnerable citizens. Tribal communities sit at the intersection of two defining national imperatives: inclusion and resource stewardship. Their lands hold an estimated 70 percent of India's mineral wealth, the majority of its forest carbon stocks, and vast reserves of biodiversity-linked traditional knowledge that are increasingly valuable in the global knowledge economy.

This Knowledge Paper has been prepared by the Chamber of Commerce and Industry of India (CCI India) as a rigorous, evidence-based instrument for structured engagement with the Ministry of Tribal Affairs. The document maps the Ministry's constitutional mandate, institutional architecture, programme performance, strategic gaps, and high-priority collaboration opportunities with analytical precision. It is designed not as a representation document but as a working partnership framework - a foundation for CCI India's engagement as a strategic implementation partner, investment mobiliser, innovation enabler, and knowledge bridge between tribal communities, industry, and government.

The intended audience for this paper includes the Union Minister of Tribal Affairs, the Secretary and senior officials of the Ministry, NITI Aayog's Social Justice and Inclusion vertical, senior bureaucrats in state tribal departments, industry leaders with tribal area operations, impact investors, development finance institutions, and international organisations engaged in indigenous peoples' development. The paper is structured to be actionable at each level - providing strategic context for Ministers, operational frameworks for implementers, and investment rationale for capital allocators.

Chamber of Commerce and Industry of India (CCI India)

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About CCI India

CCI India (The Chamber of Commerce and Industry of India) is a premier national business chamber dedicated to fostering economic growth, industry development, entrepreneurship, innovation, and investment promotion across India. As the voice of Indian business and industry, CCI India serves as a bridge between government, industry, startups, academia, investors, and civil society, facilitating meaningful collaboration for nation-building and sustainable development.

Through policy advocacy, business facilitation, research, stakeholder engagement, capacity building, and strategic partnerships, CCI India works to create an enabling environment for enterprises of all sizes. The Chamber actively supports key national initiatives such as Startup India, Make in India, Digital India, Atmanirbhar Bharat, Skill India, and Viksit Bharat 2047 by connecting innovative enterprises with government opportunities and promoting inclusive economic development.

CCI India operates through sector-specific councils, industry forums, knowledge platforms, and state-level engagements that address emerging opportunities and challenges across sectors including manufacturing, agriculture, technology, healthcare, education, infrastructure, sustainability, MSMEs, and startups. The Chamber regularly organizes policy dialogues, investment summits, business delegations, workshops, conferences, and knowledge-sharing initiatives to strengthen India's economic ecosystem.

With a strong commitment to innovation, entrepreneurship, and public-private collaboration, CCI India strives to empower enterprises, facilitate investment, enhance competitiveness, and contribute to India's journey toward becoming a globally competitive and economically resilient nation. Its role as a knowledge partner and industry catalyst enables ministries, departments, state governments, startups, and businesses to collaborate effectively in achieving national development objectives.

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1.Introduction to the Ministry of Tribal Affairs

1.1 Constitutional Mandate and Legal Framework

The Ministry of Tribal Affairs derives its constitutional mandate from a carefully constructed framework of protective provisions embedded in the Constitution of India. Article 46 of the Directive Principles of State Policy directs the State to promote with special care the educational and economic interests of Scheduled Tribes and protect them from social injustice and all forms of exploitation. The Fifth Schedule (Article 244(1)) establishes a special administrative framework for the governance of Scheduled Areas in ten states, granting Governors special powers and establishing Tribal Advisory Councils. The Sixth Schedule (Article 244(2)) creates autonomous district and regional councils in the tribal-dominated states of Assam, Meghalaya, Tripura, and Mizoram, conferring legislative, judicial, and executive powers directly on tribal self-governing bodies.

Articles 330, 332, and 342 provide for reservation of seats for Scheduled Tribes in the Lok Sabha and state legislative assemblies, and empower the President to specify Scheduled Tribes by state. The Panchayats (Extension to Scheduled Areas) Act, 1996 (PESA) extends the Panchayati Raj framework to Scheduled Areas with significant modifications that recognise tribal customary law and grant gram sabhas authority over natural resources. Collectively, these provisions create the Ministry's legal mandate: to administer, coordinate, and implement a wide range of developmental, welfare, and protective measures for India's tribal population.

1.2 Evolution of the Ministry

The institutional evolution of India's tribal affairs governance reflects the nation's changing understanding of tribal development - from paternalistic welfare approaches toward rights-based, community-driven frameworks. The Ministry of Tribal Affairs was carved out as a separate Ministry from the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment in 1999, reflecting the Government's recognition that tribal development required dedicated institutional attention with a distinct policy philosophy. Prior to this separation, tribal affairs were managed through a tribal sub-plan approach within a larger welfare ministry framework, resulting in fragmented attention and diluted resource allocation.

The post-separation evolution has been characterised by three distinct phases. The first phase (1999-2006) focused on consolidating institutional structures, establishing the Tribal Sub-Plan (TSP) framework as a mandatory earmarking mechanism in state budgets, and launching the National Tribal Welfare Mission. The second phase (2006-2014) saw landmark legislation including the Scheduled Tribes and Other Traditional Forest Dwellers (Recognition of Forest Rights) Act, 2006 - arguably the most consequential tribal legislation since the Constitution - which recognised the rights of tribal communities to forest land they had traditionally occupied and managed. The third phase (2015 onwards) has been characterised by convergence, technology adoption, and mainstreaming of tribal enterprise development.

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